

FREEDOM KITSCH

The authors document the persistent visual idioms of popular Indian art in the historical context



BHARAT MATA: INDIA'S FREEDOM MOVEMENT IN POPULAR ART
by ERWIN NEUMAYER, CHRISTINE SCHELBERGER
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■ By Geeta Doctor

If you have a passion for threes—the three bears, a triple sundae, or the Indian tricolour—this is your ticket. There are marvellous, indeed rousing, pictures of the tricolour framing, draping and waving behind the image of Bharat Mata, a visual rallying cry for yet another book on the popular art of India.

The heroes and martyrs, Bhagat Singh and his fellow conspirators, for instance, also come in threes, perhaps by chance or in keeping with artistic convention. Mother India is flanked by a noble son on either side—Gandhi and Nehru. When Gandhi becomes the Father of the Nation, he in turn extends his hands to Vallabhai Patel and Nehru and so on till we get a triumvirate of “Gandhi-Nehru-Indira” against the national flag in a poster dated around 1970. Some of the images might seem familiar—they have appeared in other studies that set out to document the extraordinary persistence of the visual idiom of Indian street or bazaar art, or have spilt over into other media such as cinema and advertising—but the manner in which they have been presented here makes them seem almost like a mini-documentary of the freedom struggle.

This is the third book by the team of Erwin Neumayer and Christine Schelberger—one begins to think of them as a pair of energetic ice-skater—using popular images from Indian art. They have already waltzed their

way with great acclaim through the life and times of Raja Ravi Varma, the painterly prince who stooped to conquer the Indian masses with the lithographs that he produced in his imported German printing press that he had set up at Lonavla in early 20th century. Neumayer is an archaeologist who specialises in the prehistoric art of South Asia. Schelberger teaches art and art history in Vienna. It's not just the European instinct for collecting and documenting a vast amount of what might be for some a trivial pursuit—bazaar billboards, political pamphlets and cheap god pictures—that makes the book so riveting, but their zest for getting the historical context right without being dogmatic allows the reader to browse through the compendium with new insights.

The political grandstanding of Mother India, or the way she has been

MOVING PICTURE: The depiction of Mother India is both stirring and comic

framed against a country rising up in revolt, is both stirring and comic in turns. As the invariably plump, if not matronly woman with hair streaming down from her shoulders assumes a martial and triumphal stance standing next to a lion or an elephant, as the case may be, one is reminded as much of a circus act, where the fair-skinned lady lion tamer poses next to the subdued beast, as of images that the editors claim might owe something to European ideals of nationhood symbolised by the romantic image of a female rampant. Has anyone considered the history of circus posters, one wonders, and their effect on the visual language of the small towns and cities through which they toured in the early 20th century?

There are also interesting asides that one may glean from images such as the one showing the four leaders at the Simla Conference in a picture printed in 1945. Only Gandhi is depicted smiling, with his teeth

on view, which is strange, since by then he had few teeth left. Among the others, Maulana Abul Kalam Azad has a slight smile, but both Muhammad Ali Jinnah and Viceroy Wavell are tightlipped. The picture tells you more than the text that goes with it does.

There's also a portrait of Jinnah done in 1947 that shows him to be the raffishly handsome man he must have been, rather than the Machiavellian manipulator that he's generally shown to be. For those who love the idea of a hero in boots and leather, the section on Subhas Chandra Bose is irresistible as the legend of the man who could have been king.

The authors have perfected the art of show and tell with all the brio of a street-smart entertainer winding his pocketbook of images. ■

